

THE MEANTIME

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*A memoir on society's clock, the myth of
falling behind, and finding peace while
everything quietly falls into place.*

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THE CLOCK THAT WAS NEVER MINE

There is a clock in the room that nobody hung on the wall.

You cannot see it, but you can feel it ticking. It tells you when you were supposed to have arrived — the age by which the career was supposed to be settled, the money supposed to be bigger, the house supposed to be owned, the person supposed to be found, the life supposed to look finished. Nobody handed you the schedule. You absorbed it, the way you absorb a language, from everyone around you at once. And then one ordinary night you looked up from your own life and felt, with a quiet and specific dread, that you were running late.

I have spent a long stretch of my life running late by that clock. Late to the milestones. Off-schedule. Behind, in the way the world measures behind. And I want to tell you what I found when I finally stopped to ask who wound the thing, and why I had agreed to keep time by it.

The sociologist Bernice Neugarten gave this clock a name. She called it the **social clock** — the internal set of age norms that tells us when the major events of a life are "supposed" to happen. Marriage by this age. Children by that one.

Established by another. The clock is not a law of nature. It is a cultural agreement, and it changes with every generation and every place. But we do not experience it as an agreement. We experience it as truth. We experience being off-schedule not as difference but as *failure* — a private verdict that something in us is broken.

Here is the first thing I learned, and I offer it to you before anything else, because it is the thing I most needed someone to say to me plainly: the clock is not measuring you. It is measuring its own idea of a life. And its idea of a life is an average, assembled from strangers, applied to a person it has never met.

You are not late. You are simply not on a schedule that was ever yours.

THE COMPARISON THAT ATE MY PEACE

The clock does its cruelest work through comparison, and comparison, in my lifetime, has become a machine.

In 1954 a psychologist named Leon Festinger proposed something he called social comparison theory. His claim was simple and old as the species: human beings have a drive to evaluate themselves, and when there is no objective measure available, we measure ourselves against other people. It is not vanity. It is how we figure out where we stand. For most of human history you compared yourself to the few dozen people in your village, and the comparison was rough and rare.

Now the village is the whole world, and it never sleeps, and it fits in your hand.

I have lain awake at two in the morning scrolling through the curated highlight reels of people I half-know, measuring my ordinary Tuesday against their wedding, their launch, their announcement, their view. I know, intellectually, that I am comparing my behind-the-scenes to their trailer. Everyone knows that now; it has become a cliché precisely because it is true. And yet knowing it did not stop the ache.

Understanding a trap and standing in it are two different experiences.

What finally loosened comparison's grip on me was not a productivity tip. It was Seneca, dead nearly two thousand years, writing to a friend: *"We suffer more often in imagination than in reality."* The Stoics understood something we have technologized into a crisis — that most of our suffering is not caused by our circumstances but by our *judgments* about our circumstances. The event is neutral. The story I tell about the event is where the pain lives. My Tuesday was not painful. The sentence I laid over my Tuesday — *everyone is ahead of you* — was painful. And that sentence, Epictetus would remind me, was the one thing entirely within my power to change. *"It is not what happens to you,"* he taught, *"but how you react to it that matters."*

I began to notice that comparison always requires a lie of scale. To compare myself to a hundred people's best moments, I had to pretend those hundred moments belonged to one continuous person who had everything, all at once, effortlessly. That person does not exist. I was losing my peace to a composite. I was grieving a life that no single human being was actually living.

ON FEELING INADEQUATE IN A LIFE YOU DID NOT CHOOSE

Some seasons of life are not chosen. They arrive. Circumstances close in — the ones you did not design, cannot yet undo, and did not deserve — and you find yourself living a life that looks, from the outside and sometimes from the inside, like it stalled.

This is the particular loneliness I want to name, because I have lived inside it: the feeling of inadequacy that comes not from failing but from being *placed*. From standing in a set of facts you would not have chosen and feeling the world's quiet judgment that a better person would not be here. That if you were smarter, or stronger, or more disciplined, the circumstances would have bent to you by now.

It is a lie, and it is a persuasive one, and it took me years and a great deal of reading to disarm it.

Kierkegaard called anxiety *"the dizziness of freedom"* — the vertigo we feel standing before all the lives we might have led. Some of that dizziness is looking backward at the fork we did not take, convinced the other path was the real one. But he also wrote the line I have carried like a stone in my pocket:

"Life can only be understood backwards; but it must be lived forwards." We judge ourselves inadequate in the meantime because we are grading a story whose meaning has not been written yet. We are standing in chapter four, holding it against the endings of other people's finished books, and calling ourselves a failure for not knowing how our own turns out.

Viktor Frankl survived the concentration camps and came out with a sentence that reorganized how I hold a circumstance I cannot change: *"When we are no longer able to change a situation, we are challenged to change ourselves."* And the deeper one, the one that took the floor out from under my self-pity: *"Everything can be taken from a man but one thing: the last of the human freedoms — to choose one's attitude in any given set of circumstances, to choose one's own way."* If a man could locate that freedom in Auschwitz, I could locate it in my small, unchosen, temporary season. The circumstances had me. But the meaning I made of them — that was still, entirely, mine.

Inadequacy is a verdict. And a verdict requires a judge whose authority you have agreed to recognize. I began, slowly, to withdraw my recognition.

EVERYTHING YOU ARE STANDING IN IS ALREADY MOVING

The single idea that did more than any other to return me to peace is not comforting in the way a pillow is comforting. It is comforting in the way solid ground is comforting. It is this: *nothing you are standing in is permanent, because permanence is not a property this universe offers.*

Heraclitus, twenty-five centuries ago, said it in the form everyone half-remembers: *"No man ever steps in the same river twice, for it is not the same river and he is not the same man."* The river you are standing in — this exact configuration of your circumstances — has already changed by the time you finish naming it. Everything flows. The Greeks called it *panta rhei*. You are not stuck. You cannot be stuck, because the ground itself is a current. What feels like stagnation is almost always change happening at a speed too slow for the eye and too honest for the ego.

Modern psychology found the same river from the other bank and gave it a plainer name: *hedonic adaptation*. We adapt to our circumstances — the good ones and the bad ones. The lottery winner returns to baseline; so, mercifully,

does the person in the hard season. Feelings that present themselves as permanent — *I will always feel this behind, this small, this late* — are, the research is clear, temporary states we are mistaking for a fixed climate. The mind is a terrible weatherman. It reports the current storm as the new permanent sky.

Marcus Aurelius, running an empire while dying slowly, wrote notes to himself at night that were really instructions for staying sane inside impermanence. *"Loss is nothing else but change, and change is Nature's delight."* And the line I have taped, at various low points, to various mirrors: *"The impediment to action advances action. What stands in the way becomes the way."* The obstacle is not blocking the path. In some seasons, the obstacle *is* the path — the exact material out of which the next version of you is being built.

You are not late and you are not stuck. You are in transit. The meantime is not a waiting room. It is a passage.

THE LONG GAME IS THE ONLY GAME THAT WAS EVER REAL

There is a kind of intelligence the clock cannot see, and learning to trust it was how I stopped panicking.

Call it strategic patience. The oldest strategists understood that the visible move is rarely the decisive one. Sun Tzu taught that the supreme skill is not to win the loud, obvious battle but to arrange conditions so thoroughly that the outcome is settled before the fighting starts. The real work is positional, quiet, and invisible to anyone keeping score by milestones. It looks like nothing. It looks, to the social clock, like falling behind. It is often the exact opposite.

Compounding is the least intuitive force in a human life. We overestimate what a season can produce and radically underestimate what a decade can. The person building quietly — reading, practicing, healing, positioning, laying groundwork nobody claps for — appears stalled right up until the moment they appear inevitable. The Stoics had a word for this posture: they distinguished between what is *up to us* and what is not, and they poured all their energy into the first category and made peace with the second. Epictetus: work

relentlessly on your judgments, your effort, your character — the things inside your control — and hold the outcomes and the timing with an open hand, because those were never yours to command.

This reframed my whole relationship to being "behind." I was not behind. I was accumulating. The meantime is where the position is built. The person who understands this stops performing progress for an audience and starts compounding it in private. They trade the anxiety of *when* for the discipline of *what* — what is mine to do today, regardless of how long the harvest takes to show.

There is a strange freedom in playing a game so long that the scoreboard stops mattering. The clock only has power over people racing on its terms. Step off the sprint and onto the long arc, and the tyranny of the timeline simply dissolves. Not because you have won its race. Because you have quit its race for a better one.

AMOR FATI, OR HOW I STOPPED FIGHTING MY OWN LIFE

For a long time I lived at war with my circumstances. I wanted a different set of facts, and until they arrived I refused to fully inhabit the ones I had. This is the most common way to lose a life: to hold your breath through the meantime, waiting to exhale into the "real" life that starts once the conditions improve.

Nietzsche, of all people — not a soft man — gave me the way out. His formula was two Latin words: *amor fati*. Love of fate. *"My formula for greatness in a human being,"* he wrote, *"is amor fati: that one wants nothing to be different, not forward, not backward, not in all eternity. Not merely to bear what is necessary, still less to conceal it — but to love it."*

I did not understand this at first. It sounded like surrender, like resigning yourself to a bad hand. It is the opposite. Amor fati is not passive acceptance; it is the decision to stop splitting your life into the parts you approve of and the parts you are enduring. It is choosing to say yes to the whole thing — including the unchosen season, including the delay, including the exact circumstances you would not have written

— because they are the only material your one actual life is made of. To reject them is to reject your life. To love them is to finally be *in* your life instead of hovering above it, waiting for a better one to begin.

Camus said it as a discovery rather than a formula: *"In the midst of winter, I found there was, within me, an invincible summer."* That is the thing the clock cannot take, the thing the circumstances cannot reach — the summer underneath, the part of you that does not depend on the conditions being right. I stopped waiting for spring. I found the summer was already inside, and it had been the whole time, buried under the noise of measuring myself against everyone else's weather.

Alan Watts made the same peace from a different door. He argued that our craving for security is itself the source of our insecurity — that to demand solid ground from a flowing universe is to guarantee anxiety. The way through is not to finally grip something permanent. It is to learn to swim. To trust yourself to the water. To stop clutching the meantime as a problem to be solved and start moving through it as the medium you actually live in.

LIVE THE QUESTIONS

I used to want answers so badly that I could not sit still inside a question. Where is this going. When does it change. Will it ever. The not-knowing felt like a wound.

Rainer Maria Rilke, writing to a young man who wanted his life resolved, offered the counsel I now consider the most useful sentence in my library: *"Be patient toward all that is unsolved in your heart and try to love the questions themselves, like locked rooms and like books written in a very foreign tongue... Live the questions now. Perhaps you will then gradually, without noticing it, live along some distant day into the answer."*

Live the questions now. Not solve them. Not outrun them. Live them — as rooms you are allowed to be inside, as a foreign language you are slowly, without noticing, coming to understand. The answer is not withheld from you as a punishment for being behind. It is being lived into, one ordinary day at a time, in a language you will only realize you learned once you are already fluent.

There is an old line attributed to Lao Tzu that I return to when I am rushing: *"Nature does not hurry, yet everything is*

accomplished." The Tao calls it *wu wei* — action without forcing, the effortless effort of moving with the grain of things instead of against it. The seed does not strain to become the tree. The river does not push the water. Everything that grows, grows on a timeline it does not announce and cannot be rushed into. I had been trying to force a harvest in a season built for roots.

EVERYTHING WILL FALL INTO PLACE

I want to end where the ache began, but on the other side of it.

The phrase *everything will fall into place* used to sound to me like something you say when you have nothing true to offer — a pat on the head, a bumper sticker, a way to end a hard conversation. I do not hear it that way anymore. I hear it now as a description of how integration actually works, and it works exactly like the words say: things *fall* — they drop out of the frantic held position you were forcing them into — and then they find their *place*, which is to say the position that was correct all along and that your gripping was preventing.

Falling into place requires the falling. It requires you to loosen your hold on the timeline, to stop arranging your life for an invisible audience keeping invisible time. The pieces cannot settle into their right position while you are clenching them in the wrong one. Peace was not the reward I got for finally getting ahead of the clock. Peace was what became available the moment I stopped keeping its time.

So here is what I know, standing in the meantime, no longer at war with it. The clock was never mine. The comparison was

always a lie of scale. The inadequacy was a verdict from a judge I no longer recognize. The season is temporary, because everything is; I am standing in a river, and the river is already carrying me somewhere I cannot yet see. The quiet building I am doing in private, that looks like nothing, is the only work that ever compounds into something. My life is not on hold until the conditions improve. My life is this — the unchosen, unfinished, off-schedule, entirely real *this* — and I have decided, in the Nietzschean sense, to love it.

You are not behind. You are becoming. And becoming, by its nature, cannot be rushed and cannot be measured against the finished thing. Be patient toward all that is unsolved in your heart. Trust the summer underneath the winter. Do the next true thing that is yours to do, and let the timing belong to the universe, which has never once, in all its history, been late.

Everything is temporary. Everything is moving. And everything — in a time that is not the clock's time, but the right time — falls into place.



Author's note: This book was drafted to carry the themes and the voice; the specific circumstances are left open on purpose so the story can hold your own. Wherever you want the exact life details — the season, the setbacks, the particular room you wrote this from — layer them in, and the scaffolding here will hold them.

NOTES

